already been telling my colleagues when they consult me that I would like you to be asked first or jointly with me.'

The letter was an unmistakable indication that Ratan would, henceforth, be involved in all the important group decisions. It was a decision of doubtless import. By implication, it also revealed a certain degree of authority that he now had over the companies controlled by the stalwarts. And as months passed, JRD found Ratan's performance growing in areas critical for the group.

Ratan, however, was still unsure of JRD's intentions. He says that he had always entertained the belief that it would be Mody who would finally take over as chairman, Tata Sons.

But if Ratan was like JRD in many ways, he was also unlike the chairman in others. The young Tata was a man of few words, an introvert. JRD, on the other hand, was the life of the party. Given the corporate culture of India, where connections are made during meetings and parties, and decisions are influenced on such occasions, Ratan's reserved nature was viewed as a disadvantage.

Commenting on his style, Kissinger said: 'He [Ratan] [is] not [as] dramatic as Jeh, but he's a man of enormous solidity and a leading thought.' His manners are 'unobtrusive' and his views are designed to elicit 'cooperation' as opposed to it being viewed as an 'imposition'.

Contrary to public perception, Ratan was not always reclusive. He formed enduring friendships and was able to convince both political and business leaders about his sincerity of purpose and the morality of his approach. When Rajiv Gandhi became Prime Minister in 1984, it worked to the group's advantage. Ratan said in an interview: 'With the first round of liberalization under Rajiv Gandhi, these [high-tech industries of strategic importance] were precisely some of the areas that were thrown open (to the private sector). Suddenly our success rate in getting licences, was 100 per cent.'

'Their friendship and mutual admiration brought about a major change in the group's attitude towards the government and vice versa,' commented an economic daily. It also led the Prime Minister to nominate Ratan as chairman of Air-India, then a government-owned airline. He did so by overruling the proposal of the civil aviation minister, Jagdish Tytler, to appoint Russi Mody instead.